AI & SOCIETY COURSE

Prof. Mor Naaman

Part 6

THE WAY FORWARD WITH AI

Unit 6-1: The Way Forward with AI

1



2

Let's review

What did we cover?

3

PART 1 - AI FOUNDATIONS · UNIT 1-1

What Is Generative AI?

We saw how LLMs are created and what are the steps involved: pre-training, fine-tuning, reinforcement learning, and a system prompt each shape what the model does.

Unit 1 of 18 in today's recap

4

PART 1 - AI FOUNDATIONS · UNIT 1-2

From LLMs to Advanced AI Systems

We covered how LLMs transform from "guessing the next word" to powerful, helpful agents – with RAG, reasoning models, and tools that can act.

Unit 2 of 18 in today's recap

5

PART 1 - AI FOUNDATIONS · UNIT 1-3

Data and Evaluation

Models train on massive, English-dominated web data and are graded on specific benchmarks that do not represent the full global experience.

Unit 3 of 18 in today's recap

6

PART 1 · AI FOUNDATIONS · UNIT 1-4

Bias and Fairness

AI bias enters at every stage of model development, and chatbots lean Western regardless of the language used or who built them.

Unit 4 of 10 in today's recap

7

7

PART 2 · AI AND INDIVIDUALS · UNIT 2-1

How Do People Use AI?

AI can boost short-term performance and creativity, often at a cost to real learning, critical thinking, and the diversity of our ideas.

Unit 5 of 10 in today's recap

8

8

PART 2 · AI AND INDIVIDUALS · UNIT 2-2

Trust and Reliance

Fluent, confident AI is not the same as correct AI. But because of these features, we trust AI too easily.

Unit 6 of 10 in today's recap

9

9

PART 2 · AI AND INDIVIDUALS · UNIT 2-3

Companions and Relationships

AI companionship is the "fast food" of social connection: it is always there and very enjoyable, but it can hurt our real relationships.

Unit 7 of 10 in today's recap

10

10

PART 2 · AI AND INDIVIDUALS · UNIT 2-4

AI Persuasion

AI is a highly effective, often invisible persuader. One way it persuades is by throwing facts at us, but this same quality could also make it less accurate.

Unit 8 of 10 in today's recap

11

11

PART 3 · AI AND COMMUNICATION · UNIT 3-1

AI-Mediated Communication

AI increasingly participates in human-to-human exchanges, known as AI-mediated communication. It is increasingly the norm, but suspicion of AI use quietly erodes trust as we've lost key communication signals we haven't replaced yet.

Unit 9 of 10 in today's recap

12

12

PART 3 - AI AND THE INFORMATION ENVIRONMENT - UNIT 3-2

AI, Culture, and Information

AI slop, deepfakes, and the "liar's dividend" are degrading the information ecosystem and hurting trustworthy, reliable information sources. New models are now learning from an unreliable Web.

Unit 10 of 18 in today's recap

13

PART 4 - CHALLENGES FOR AI IMPLEMENTATION - UNIT 4-1

Trust and Safety

There are guardrails in at every stage to prevent humans from using AI for evil, but jailbreaks keep finding a way through, especially in other languages. Worse: open-weight models can strip the protections out entirely.

Unit 11 of 18 in today's recap

14

PART 4 - CHALLENGES FOR AI IMPLEMENTATION - UNIT 4-2

Privacy

AI collects, links, and infers information about us at a scale the old internet never could, turning scraped data and our prompts into an intimate picture of us.

Unit 12 of 18 in today's recap

15

PART 4 - CHALLENGES FOR AI IMPLEMENTATION - UNIT 4-3

Intellectual Property

Copyright wasn't built for the AI age: creators get little consent, credit, or compensation while AI companies build billion-dollar products on their work.

Unit 13 of 18 in today's recap

16

PART 4 - CHALLENGES FOR AI IMPLEMENTATION - UNIT 4-4

The Economics of AI

Whoever owns the model and the data center captures the value of the work, even when the data behind it came from all of us, for free.

Unit 14 of 18 in today's recap

17

PART 5 - AI'S WORLDWIDE IMPACT - UNIT 5-1

AI and Work

AI is boosting productivity in writing, support, and code. However, "workslop" and falling entry-level hiring show the real risk is who's left to review and verify the AI output.

Unit 15 of 18 in today's recap

18

PART 5 - AI'S WORLDWIDE IMPACT - UNIT 5-2

AI in Education

AI isn't a great scaffold for learning by default, although with careful design it can help. Teaching and assessment can be redesigned to deliberately "lean in" and "lean out."

Unit 16 of 18 in today's recap

19

PART 5 - AI'S WORLDWIDE IMPACT - UNIT 5-3

AI and Democracy

AI's risk to democracy includes epistemic risks (what we know), material risks (how we run elections), and foundational risk (who holds the power and how they can use it).

Unit 17 of 18 in today's recap

20

PART 5 - AI'S WORLDWIDE IMPACT - UNIT 5-4

The Environmental Cost of AI

AI *may* help solve climate change one day — but so far it is challenging power grids, water supplies, and the communities living next to data centers.

Unit 18 of 18 in today's recap

21

So where does this leave us?

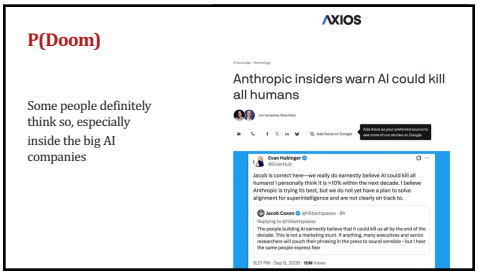
23



24

P(Doom)

Some people definitely think so, especially inside the big AI companies



25

My one biggest issue: Inequality

26

Global North vs. Global South?

> *Seven countries — the wealthy, industrialized members of the G7 — are party to every major AI governance effort; more than a hundred other states are party to none.*

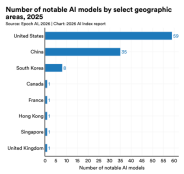
Training data, resources, engineering efforts are centered in the U.S., Europe, and China.

Models are showing Western biased; are more useful and available to people in the Global North.

Chesterman (2026). Silicon Sovereigns: Artificial Intelligence, International Law, and the Tech-Industrial Complex

27

Global North vs. Global South?



Stanford HAI Artificial Intelligence Index Report, 2025

28

More important divide: private vs. public

The most important divide may not be East-West or North-South, but public-private.

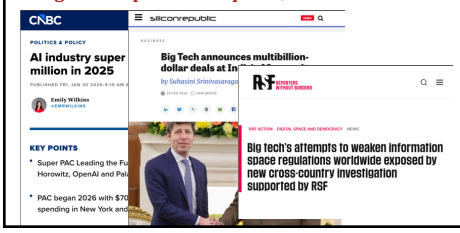
> *the nature and scale of the power wielded by today's tech giants rivals the role occupied by the East India Company in the early nineteenth century, when it controlled half of global trade and had its own army.*

AI is shifting economic and, increasingly, political power away from governments.

Chesterman (2026). Silicon Sovereigns: Artificial Intelligence, International Law, and the Tech-Industrial Complex

29

Large AI companies have power, influence

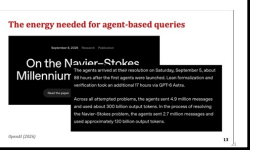


30

Large AI companies have resources

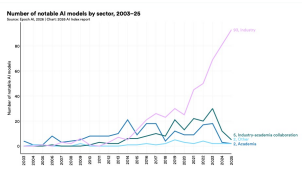
September '26: OpenAI claimed to have resolved a Navier-Stokes Millennium Prize problem; cost of several million dollars in compute.

The pace of innovation will keep accelerating for those with the access and capital to. Who is left doing the manual work?



31

Large AI companies have resources



Stanford HAI Artificial Intelligence Index Report, 2025

32

Capital vs. labor: an age-old story

33

The techno-optimist view

> *The productivity boost from technologies such as AI "drives wages up, not down. This is perhaps the most counterintuitive idea in all of economics, but it's true, and we have 300 years of history that prove it."*

FALSE

— Marc Andreessen (a16z.com, 2023), "The Techno-Optimist Manifesto", via Silicon Sovereigns



34

Better lives for employees?

> *New automated staffing schedules use sophisticated algorithms to rotate employees among jobs that use different muscle-tendon groups, to decrease repetitive motion.*

— Jeff Bezos(Amazon, 2020), "Shareholder Report 2020", via Silicon Sovereigns

Does this sound like making an employee's life better... or making better use of their body?



35

Please read

RESEARCH-ARTICLE | OPEN ACCESS

Reckoning with the Political Economy of AI: Avoiding Decoys in Pursuit of Accountability

Authors: Janet Vertesi, danah boyd, Alex S Taylor, Benjamin Shestakofsky, Authors info & Claims

FAccT '26: The 2026 ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency • Pages 2186 - 2205
https://doi.org/10.1145/3805689.3806739

Published: 25 June 2026 Publication History

Check for updates

36

How should we continue?

What are some moral guidelines for AI?

37

The Pope's message about AI

Pope Leo XIV, "Magnifica Humanitas: On Safeguarding the Human Person in the Time of Artificial Intelligence".

(Published May 25, 2026)



38

1 Challenge 1: the question of values

What (and whose) values do, or should, steer the path of this technology? Technology arrives in the world with built-in assumptions: what's worth measuring, what counts as success, who counts as an outlier, and what kind of person the system imagines when it provides its services.

39

2 Challenge 2: The question of efficiency

What happens to a world that becomes addicted, above all, to efficiency? AI fits perfectly into a world that measures everything: performance, output, risk, engagement. But some things can't be compressed into a metric — education, care, democracy, conversation, forgiveness, moral deliberation.

40

3 Challenge 3: The question of objectivity

Is AI "objective," and what does it mean to call it that? Algorithmic decisions often look cleaner than human ones. A fluent chatbot response or algorithm's output gives the output the appearance of fact which makes it harder, not easier, to see that is may be biased.

41

4 Challenge 4: The question of connection

What happens to human relationships when we regularly encounter this non-human "other"? AI can already simulate listening, patience, advice, empathy, even intimacy. Real connection requires reciprocity, patience, and vulnerability. A simulation of it may teach us to accept less or drive us away from others.

42

5 Challenge 5: The question of power

Who holds the power of artificial intelligence? Whoever controls the models, the data, the compute, and the interfaces holds more than a tool — they hold infrastructure that shapes work, education, credit, health, information, and reputation. This cannot be left to the companies alone.

43

Where that leaves you

There are no answers.

I hope that after this course, you're better able to reason through all of these Challenges.

44

Q&A

Ask me anything!

45

Last items

Winners, social media, souvenirs, and group photos

46

Social Media Notice

Sorry, I can only accept connections from people who I meaningfully engaged with.

Feel free to follow me on:

@prof.mor.cornell

@informor.bsky.social

47

Winners (2 hats, 1 honorable mention…)

- Talha Muammar
- Safwan Ismaun Amin
- Md. Jawadul Hasan

48